least enable one to imagine the perspective of the subjects of the Mauryan state facing this novel way of looking at them.

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Communicating with provincial officials lay at the heart of the political system in ancient India. The provinces were, as we have seen—when noting Ashoka's movements to Taxila in the northwest, Malwa in the south, and Kalinga in the east—spread out over thousands of kilometres. Ashoka had inherited an empire extending from Afghanistan to Karnataka and from Gujarat to Bengal. Administering an entity of this size required regularly touching base with provinces, these being frequently governed by princes of the royal family. Having served as viceroy at Ujjayini himself, Ashoka seems to have maintained the practice of delegating close male kin to run the provincial bulwarks of his empire. Directions and orders were frequently given to these local functionaries through edicts. Their centrality can be gauged from the fact that directives for both peace and war appear within them. The decrees also include commands by the king concerning punishment and favour, gifts and exemptions, authorizations for issuing orders and carrying out certain required works.[3] The *Arthashastra* considered it necessary for such communiqués to be written with clarity and prescribes the employment of literate scribes with a beautiful hand who 'should listen with an attentive mind to the command of the king and set it down in writing.'[4]

The importance of royal communications as an anchor of imperial administration is in inverse proportion to what has remained of them: no messages of any kind prior to the time of Ashoka have survived. The usual materials used for writing were palm leaf, birch-bark (or 'bhurjapatra', *Betula utilis*), cotton cloth, and possibly wooden boards. These are mentioned in several textual sources and, being all highly perishable, specimens have never shown up.[5]